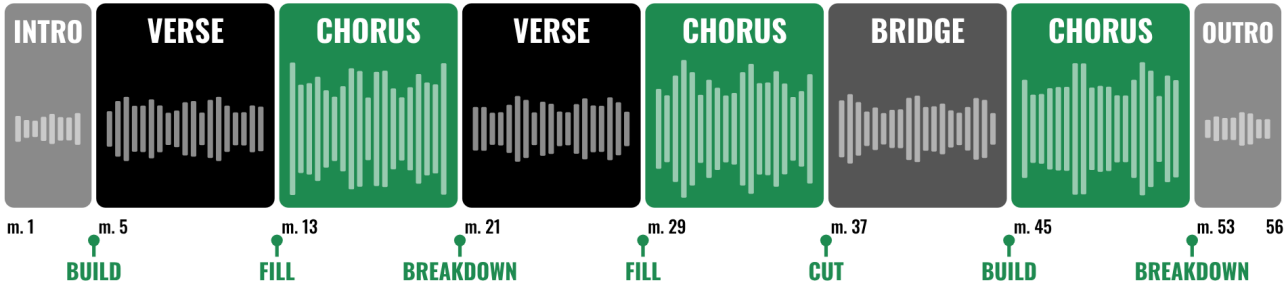
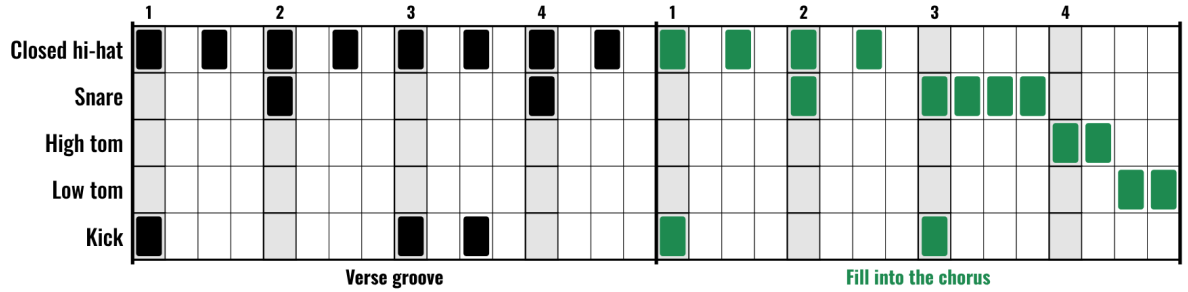
HUDSON BEAT





STEMS & GROOVES

Feat. In the Air Tonight

DIGITAL MUSIC PRODUCTION · UNIT 2 · DAY 1 · DRUMS OVER STEMS IN LOGIC PRO

LISTEN: MUSIC WITH NO DRUMS

YOUR FOUNDATION STEM

teacher plays 60 seconds

No drums yet: that part is your job.

- What is this music doing?
- Where does the energy change?
- Where does a new section feel like it starts?

WHAT THE HECK IS A STEM?

- One instrument or group, pulled out of a recording
- Your stem: everything except the drums
- Your job: write drums that belong
- Listen first, then respond

SIX DAYS, TWO PARTS

DAY 1

LEARNING + FOUNDATION START · FOUNDATION

Listen to the stem; the four transitions; map the sections; start the A pattern

DAY 2

WORKING: FOUNDATION · FOUNDATION

Finish A, build a contrasting B, place both; gain staging

DAY 3

TRANSITION WORKSHOP + FULL SONG START · FULL SONG

Transition workshop; map every section change; build transitions in 64 steps

DAY 4

WORKING: FULL SONG · FULL SONG

Finish every transition; play it through; optional reverb bus

DAY 5

SUBMISSION + PRESENTATION PREP · SUBMIT

Checklists and rubric; submit; write three feedback questions

DAY 6

PRESENTING · PRESENT

Play it with the stem; why that transition? You mixed a song

LISTEN: A FAMOUS DRUM ENTRANCE

IN THE AIR TONIGHT

Phil Collins

Teacher: play from about 3:00 to 4:00 from YouTube or Spotify.

- What keeps time before the big drums arrive?
- What happens right before they come in?
- Why does it hit so hard?

FOUR WAYS TO ANNOUNCE A CHANGE

1 · Drum fill

a rhythmic variation in the last 1–2 measures that signals a change is coming

2 · Breakdown

strip to one element (kick only, hi-hat only) before the new section hits

3 · Cut

complete silence for 1–2 beats before the next section drops

4 · Build

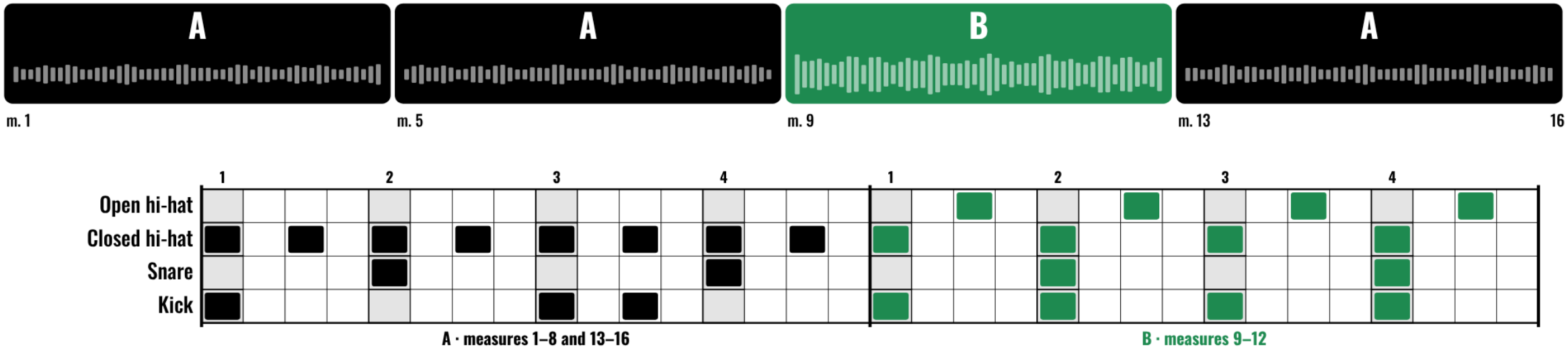
add elements progressively in the last measure to increase energy into the change

You will use these in Part 2. Every section change gets one.

LISTEN BEFORE YOU BUILD

1. Download one stem from the Foundation folder
2. Play all 16 measures twice: touch nothing
3. Where does the energy change? Count measures
4. Arrangement markers: A or B, 4 measures each
5. Only then open Drum Machine Designer

WORKED EXAMPLE: A AND B OVER THE STEM



- A: laid back, closed hi-hat eighths
- Placed A, A, B, A: it follows the stem
- B: kick on every beat, open hi-hats
- Tell them apart without looking

WATCH ME: BUILD YOUR A PATTERN

1. New track: Software Instrument, an Electronic Drum Kit
2. Control-click at the first A: Create Pattern Region
3. Kick, snare, closed hi-hat first
4. Play it with the stem: does it fit?
5. Save it: Your Name - Foundation

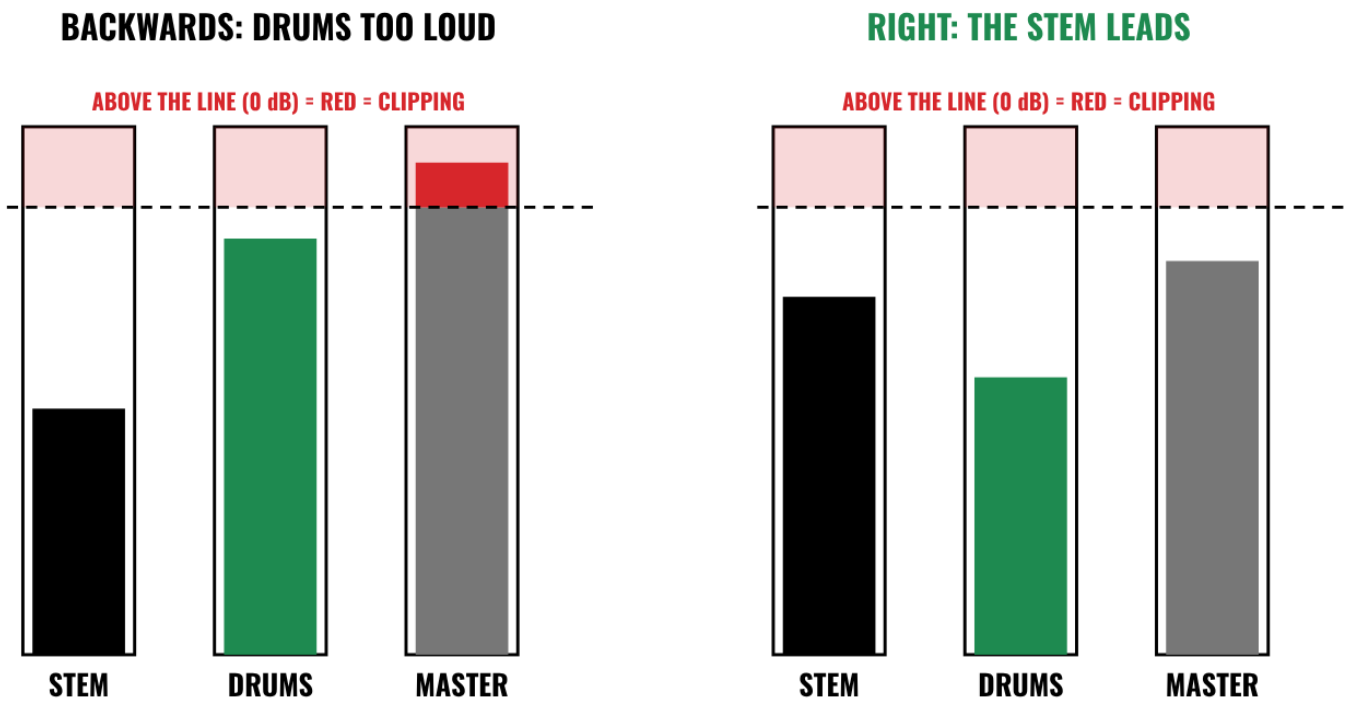
DOES IT FIT?

- Two volunteers: A pattern with the stem
- Does the groove fit the feel of the section?
- Do the drums follow the music?
- Or does the music follow the drums?

PLAY A, THEN PLAY B

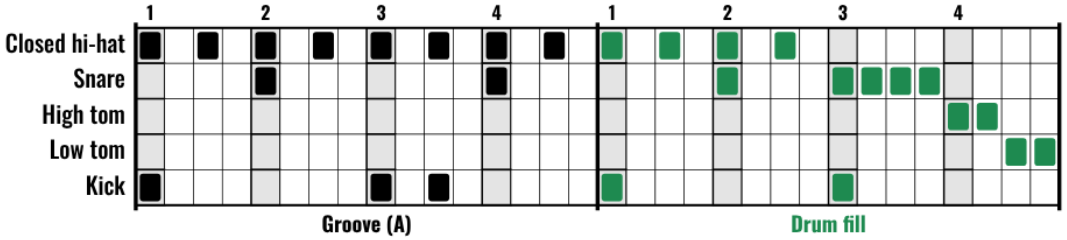
- Can you feel the difference without looking?
- If A is busy, B might be stripped back
- If A is laid back, B might add energy
- Then copy both across every section

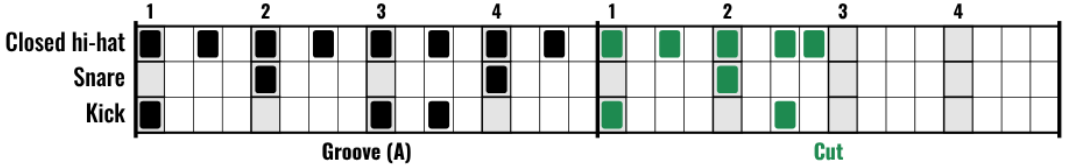
MIXING MOMENT: GAIN STAGING

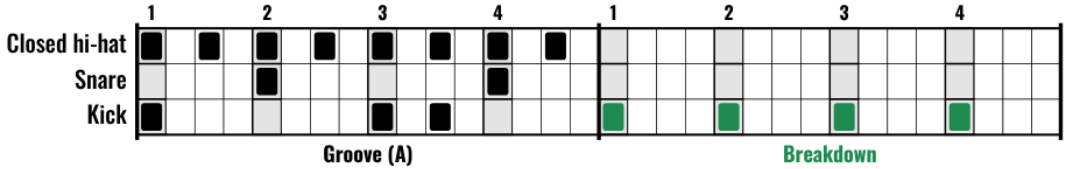


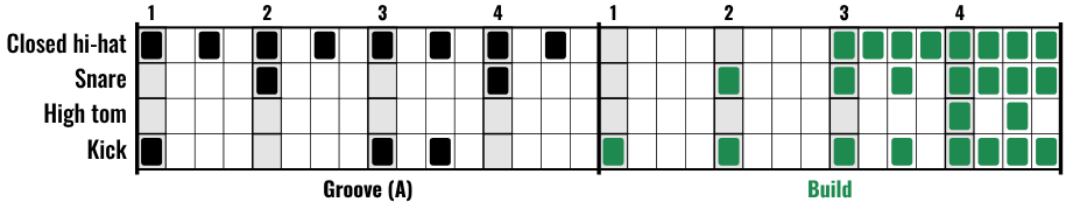
- Never into the red
- Turn other things down
- The stem leads
- Drums support it
- Every element audible

TRANSITION WORKSHOP



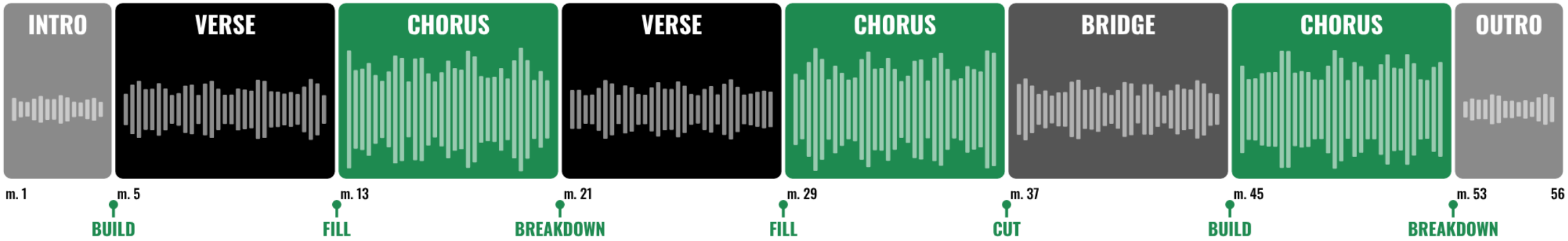






- Fill: the groove breaks into snare, then toms
- Cut: two beats of complete silence
- Breakdown: one element left (the kick)
- Build: a sound joins on every beat

WORKED EXAMPLE: MAP EVERY CHANGE



- 8 sections, 7 changes, 7 transitions
- A cut before the quieter bridge
- Four types, each for its moment
- A build before the big last chorus

WATCH ME: A TRANSITION IN 64 STEPS

1. Copy the groove into the measures before the change
2. Step Sequencer: set the pattern length to 64 steps
3. Change only the last measure (or two)
4. Play into the new section: does it announce it?
5. Listen, then move to the next change

PLAY IT ALL THE WAY THROUGH

- Every section change should feel intentional
- If a transition adds nothing, rework it
- A cut only works if the music earns it
- The stem is the star: drums support it

OPTIONAL: A REVERB BUS

1. Mixer (X): on the drums, click a Send slot, choose a bus
2. Logic adds an Aux channel strip
3. On the Aux: an Audio FX slot, then ChromaVerb
4. Turn the Send knob up slowly
5. Not graded: the full lesson is in Unit 6

FOUNDATION: WHAT YOU TURN IN

- [ ] A and B written and placed across all sections
- [ ] At least 3 layers per pattern
- [ ] Nothing clipping, everything audible
- [ ] Named as on your project sheet
- [ ] MP3 + .zip, submitted before presenting

FULL SONG: WHAT YOU TURN IN

- [ ] Every section change labeled, with a transition
- [ ] At least two transition types
- [ ] Each transition fits the music
- [ ] Mix: the drums serve the stem
- [ ] Named; MP3 + .zip submitted
- [ ] Three Padlet feedback questions posted

HOW IT'S SCORED

FOUNDATIONS	5 = A and B have distinct personalities; placement precise and intentional.	/ 5
FULL SONG	5 = Every transition feels inevitable: the right type for each moment.	/ 5
TECHNICAL SKILL / DAW USE	5 = 64-step mode for transition detail; clean, confident workflow.	/ 5
GAIN STAGING & MIX	5 = Drums sit perfectly with the stem; nothing clips; one cohesive piece.	/ 5
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	5 = Named, on time, confident, three thoughtful Padlet questions.	/ 5

SCORED 2 TO 5 · TOTAL / 25

PRESENTATION DAY

- Play your full drum track with the stem
- Point to each transition: why that type?
- Respond to at least 2 projects
- You responded to music that already existed

ONE LAST THING...

- You listened first.
- You wrote drums that belong.
- You announced every change.
- You mixed a song.

